Lecture 1: Introduction — Power, Politics, and Political Science (MDJ)

Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

Required reading: OD ch. 1 · Ansell (2023) ch. 1

Core theme: *What is politics, and how do we study it?* Two complementary lenses — OD gives you the **discipline's toolkit** (what comparative politics is + the main theory families), Ansell gives you a **single analytical engine** (political economy: self-interest → collective-action problems → the need for political "promises").

OD Ch. 1 — Introduction

Book: Orvis & Drogus, *Introducing Comparative Politics: Concepts and Cases in Context*, 5th ed. (CQ Press/SAGE, 2021)

Chapter résumé

The opening chapter defines the field and hands you the analytical vocabulary used for the rest of the book. It answers three "meta" questions — *what* comparative politics is, *why* to study it, and *how* comparativists do research — and then lays out the **three key questions** that organize the whole discipline: **What explains political behavior? Who rules? Where and why?** Most of the chapter is a guided tour of the competing **theory families** used to answer the first two questions. It closes with the book's plan (three parts) and its method of teaching through **eleven recurring country case studies**.

> ★ **The heart of the chapter:** the whole field collapses into **three questions** — *what explains behaviour? · who rules? · where & why?* — answered with the **Interests / Beliefs / Structures** and **Pluralist / Elite** frameworks, all read through **Lukes' three dimensions of power**. Master those and you can attack any comparative-politics question.

Key concepts / "modes" to use

These are the analytical toolkits you're expected to *apply* to cases later:

- **Three dimensions of power** (Lukes) — the lens for spotting *where* power operates.
- **Empirical vs. normative theory** — always separate "what *is*" from "what *ought to be*."
- **Research methods** — single-case study · comparative method (most-similar / most-different systems) · quantitative statistics.
- **Explaining behavior → 3 families:** Interests · Beliefs · Structures.
- **Who rules → 2 families:** Pluralist vs. Elite theory.

Section-by-section main points

Comparative Politics: What Is It? / How to Study It?

What is politics? *(expanded with the lecture — MDJ)*

- **OD's definition:** politics = "*the process by which human communities make collective decisions*" (any scale, village → international body). This is a **procedural** definition — it's about *how* decisions get made, not their content. Four **implications**:
  - **Group, not private, decisions** — it concerns the group.
  - **The whole community** — decisions normally bind everyone.
  - **The process** — focus is on the decision-making *process*.
  - **≠ polity / policy** — distinguish **politics** (the process) from **polity** (the rules/institutions) and **policy** (the outcomes).
- Also: the process applies **across regime types**, needn't involve **large groups**, and is **not necessarily inclusive** (decisions are often made by small, unelected groups).
- **The distributional definitions** (what OD's definition leaves out — *the distribution of resources*):
  - **Lasswell (1936):** politics = "*who gets what, when, how.*"
  - **Easton (1953):** politics = "*the authoritative allocation of values for a society.*"
  - → politics as a **distributional game**: the capacity to distribute **material and non-material resources** (who wins, who loses).
  - Two key **assumptions** behind this view: ① **scarcity** of resources (no scarcity → no distributional battle) and ② **preference heterogeneity** (people want different, often conflicting, things).
- **Comparative politics** = the subfield comparing power & decision-making *within* countries (contrast: **international relations** studies *between*/beyond states).
- **Power — the three faces / dimensions.** *This is the chapter's master concept — it recurs as the lens for every theory later, so know it cold.* The lecture runs **one example** (a parliamentary **tax increase**) through all three so the differences are clear:

Face	Who (attribution)	Core idea	The tax example	Power =
1st · Decision-making	**Dahl (1957)**	A gets B to do something B would not otherwise do — **observable** conflict & decisions	A majority in Parliament passes the tax increase despite strong opposition	**winning an observable decision**
2nd · Agenda-setting	**Bachrach & Baratz (1962)**	Power through **non-decision-making** — keeping threatening issues **off the agenda** via rules/values	Powerful actors keep the tax increase off Parliament's agenda, so no debate or vote ever happens	**controlling what gets decided**
3rd · Ideological	**Lukes (1974)**	Shaping people's **wants, perceptions & preferences** — even with *no observable conflict*	People come to see taxing the wealthy as harmful/illegitimate, so the demand never even arises	**shaping wants & preferences**

- **The difference in one line:** the 1st face is about *winning* a visible fight; the 2nd is about *stopping the fight from happening*; the 3rd is about *making sure no one wants to fight in the first place*. Power gets **less visible** as you go down.
- **Why it's central — the recurring pay-off:** each later theory is graded by *which dimension it can see*. Rational choice & pluralists see essentially only the **1st**; rational-choice institutionalists add the **2nd**; psychological theories, postmodern discourse, historical institutionalism and elite theory reach into the **2nd & 3rd**. Being able to say "this theory only captures the first dimension" is a core analytical move.
- **Worked example of the move (straight from the book):** *Rational choice* accepts people's preferences **as given** and only asks how they rationally pursue them — so it lives purely in the **1st dimension**, ignoring how preferences are *formed*. That is exactly why it "can't explain preferences in advance" and stumbles on the **cross-national union puzzle** (why French unions went communist while US unions chased only wages): it has no way to see the **3rd-dimensional** forces that *shaped* those preferences. **Psychological theories** and **historical institutionalists**, which do reach the 3rd dimension, are what step in to explain it. → *This is the template: name the theory, name the dimension(s) it can't see, then name a rival theory that reaches further.*

Why Study Comparative Politics? — three benefits

1. Understand political events in specific countries (and inform foreign policy).
2. Draw **lessons** transferable from one place to another (e.g. presidential systems may worsen post-civil-war conflict — invisible if you only study the US).
3. Build **broad theories** of how politics works.

How Do Comparativists Study Politics? — methods

- No lab: political actors *react* to being studied, so no perfect control.

- **Empirical theory** = explains what *does* occur (describe pattern → explain cause → predict). **Normative theory** = what *ought* to occur. The discipline is mostly empirical, but normative concerns shape which questions get asked (and that's legitimate).
- **Three research methods:**
  - **Single-case study** — deep dive into one case; generates/tests theory; *process tracing* links causes→effects; **deviant cases** expose theory limits. Never definitive beyond itself.
  - **Comparative method** — mimic the lab via careful case selection:
    - **Most-similar systems** — cases alike in many ways, differ on the key variable.
    - **Most-different systems** — cases differing in many ways but sharing the outcome (e.g. revolutions: France, Russia, China, Iran…).
  - **Quantitative statistical techniques** — reduce evidence to numbers, compare hundreds of cases (e.g. the civil-war & diamonds study: civil war driven more by *lootable resources* than ethnicity).
- **Scientific-method vocabulary:** theory · hypothesis · variable · **dependent** vs **independent** variable · **control**.
- Best modern scholarship *combines* methods (quant for patterns + case studies for causal depth).

Three Key Questions in Comparative Politics

1. **What explains political behavior?** (core of all political science)
2. **Who rules?**
3. **Where and why?** (comparativists' distinctive contribution — the same explanation across different times/places?)

Q1 — What Explains Political Behavior? → three answer-families

*The chapter's (and the exam's) core. Each family splits into competing theories — below, each with its **core idea**, its **critique**, and which **face of power** it "sees." Learn the theory names + one line each.*

① Interests — behaviour = actors pursuing their own preferences

Theory	Core idea	Critique	Sees face
Rational choice	Rational individuals pursue self-defined **preferences** instrumentally (borrowed from economics; starts at the individual).	Can't know preferences **in advance** → weak predictive power; struggles with cross-country variation. Group-behaviour critics: **Achen & Bartels**.	1st
Psychological	**Non-rational** factors — personal experience, **emotions**, personality — shape behaviour (**Petersen** on fear; **Hetherington & Weiler** on personality).	Its focus on the individual makes **group** behaviour hard to explain.	3rd

② Beliefs — behaviour = values & ideas

Theory	Core idea	Critique	Sees face
Political culture	Shared **attitudes, values, symbols** shape behaviour. *Modernist:* clear, identifiable civic values (Almond & Verba's **civic culture**; **postmaterialist** shift, Inglehart). *Postmodernist:* culture = symbols open to interpretation in **discourse** (Foucault).	Do countries really have *one* culture? Culture may be an **effect**, not a cause; postmodernism accused of explaining nothing.	2nd–3rd
Political ideology	A **systematic, conscious belief-set** guides action (liberalism, communism, fascism).	May just **justify** actions really driven by self-interest or culture.	3rd

③ Structures — behaviour = shaped & limited by broad structures

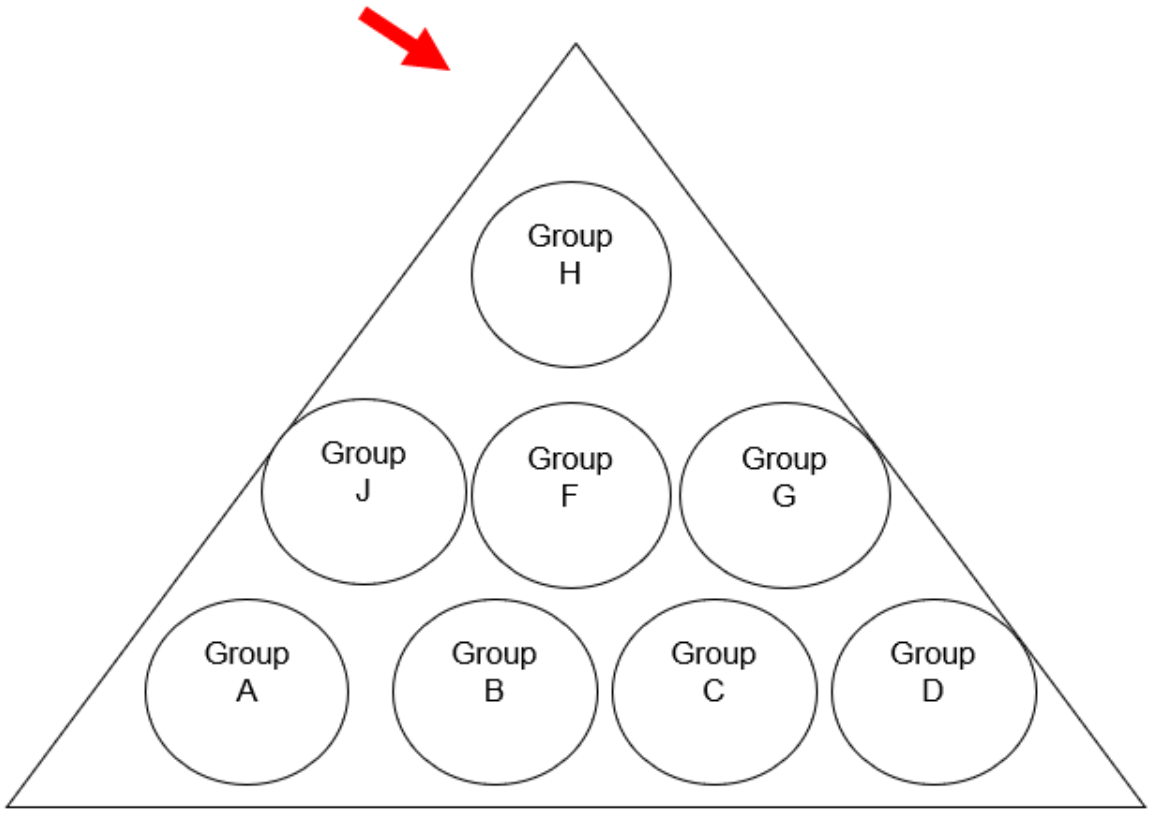
Theory	Core idea	Critique	Sees face
Marxism	Behaviour explained by **class conflict** rooted in the economic system (bourgeoisie vs proletariat — **Marx**).	Overlooks **non-economic** motives (religion, nationalism) and other sources of power.	2nd–3rd
Institutionalism	**Institutions — the "rules of the game"** — shape behaviour (*rational-choice institutionalist*, **Weingast**; *historical institutionalist*, **Haggard & Kaufman**; e.g. the US two-term tradition).	Institutions may **reflect** self-interest or culture rather than *cause* behaviour.	2nd (RC) / all 3 (historical)

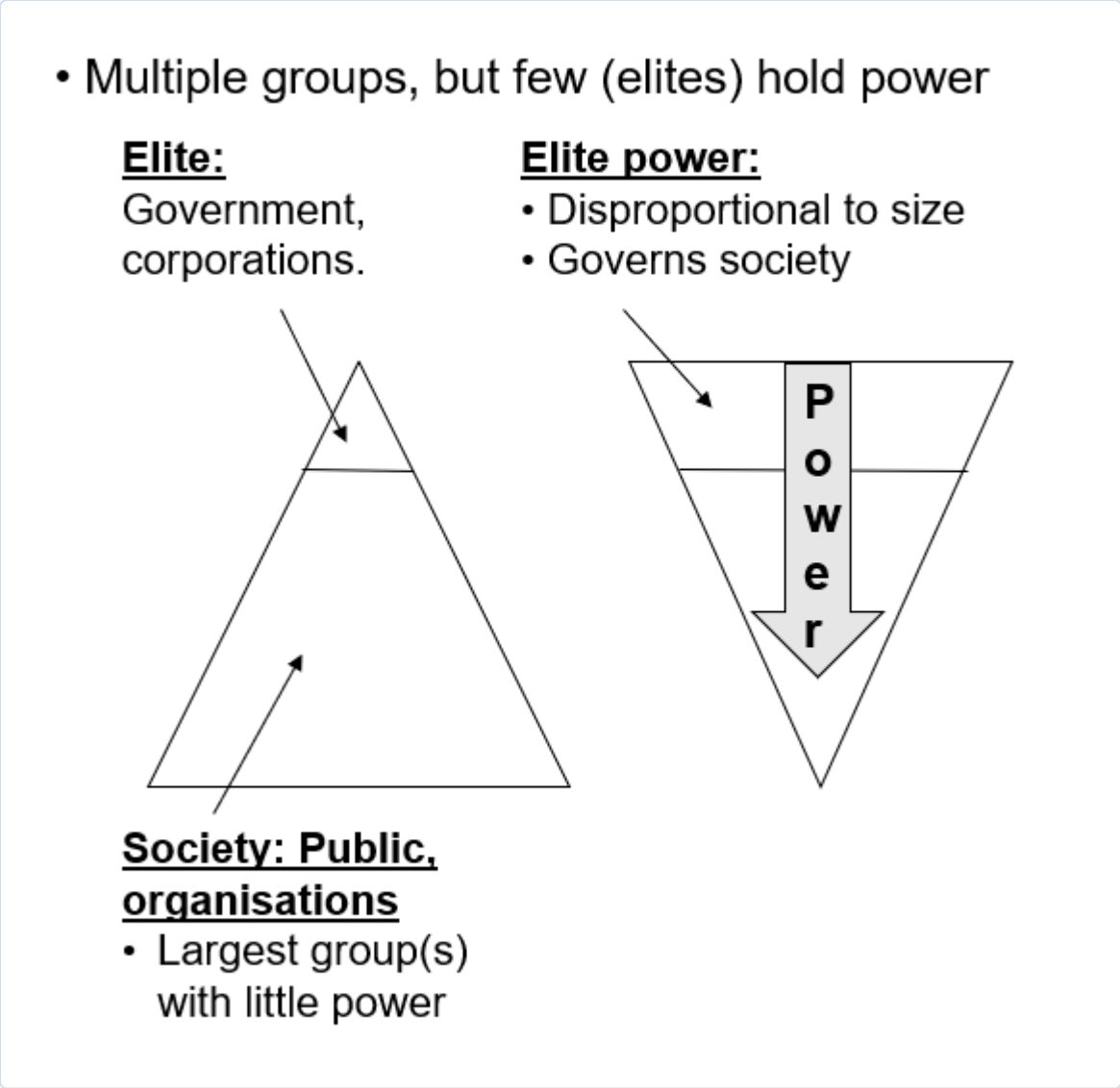
Q2 — Who Rules? → two answer-families

- **Pluralist theories** (classic statement: **Robert Dahl**, *Who Governs?* 1961) — society = many competing groups; power *dispersed*; no group wins permanently; policy = compromise. (Thinks mostly in the **1st dimension** of power.) Claims to apply even to authoritarian states (Soviet factions; African patron–client networks).
- **Elite theories** — every society ruled by a small elite controlling ~all power (uses **2nd & 3rd dimensions**). Variants:
  - **Marxism** — ruling class = owners of the economy (bourgeoisie); state = "executive committee of the bourgeoisie."
  - **Power elite** (C. Wright Mills) — interlocking economic + political + military elites.
  - **Oligarchy** (Winters) — extreme wealth as power, used to protect wealth.
  - **Patriarchy** (feminist) — rule by men; politics/military tied to masculinity.
  - **Racial elite / "new Jim Crow"** (Alexander) — one race maintains dominance via law, wealth, discourse.
- **Test for who rules:** Who holds formal power? Who influences decisions? Who benefits? → few = elite; many = pluralist.

Visualising it (from the lecture):

Multiple groups hold and compete over power:
No singular center of power





How to read them. *Pluralist* (first diagram): power is **dispersed** among many competing groups — *no single centre*. *Elitist* (second): a **small elite** (government, corporations) sits at the top and holds power **disproportionate to its size**, while the **largest group — the public/society — has little power**; the inverted triangle shows **power flowing *down*** onto them. Same society, opposite claim about where power really sits.

Q3 — Where and Why?

- Add the **comparative dimension** to Q1 & Q2: why do welfare states differ (see the Sweden vs US welfare state case)? Explanations compete — rational choice / ideology / institutions. Comparison across cases reveals patterns a single case hides.

Plan of the Book

- **Part I** — the state (what it is, strong/weak; state–citizen–regime; state–identity).
- **Part II** — how political systems work (democratic & authoritarian institutions; participation; regime change).
- **Part III** — political economy & policy.

- **11 recurring country cases:** 4 wealthy democracies (Britain, Germany, Japan, US); 2 post-communist (China, Russia); largest enduring democracy (India); the one theocracy (Iran); 3 post-authoritarian democracies (Brazil, Mexico, Nigeria).

Cases & examples

The concrete cases the chapter uses. Each one: *what actually happened → what it illustrates*.

- **Tunisia vs Syria (2011).** Both were swept up in the Arab Spring protests, yet the outcomes split completely: Tunisia negotiated a relatively **peaceful transition to democracy**, while Syria collapsed into a long, brutal **civil war**. → *Illustrates:* why comparison matters — understanding a country's internal dynamics has real foreign-policy stakes; it also undercuts the lazy claim that "Arab/Islamic culture" is uniformly anti-democratic (same culture-family, opposite results).
- **Post-civil-war presidentialism.** Americans treat their directly-elected presidency as *the* stable model. But in a country just out of civil war it's **winner-take-all**: only one side's candidate can win the top job, so the losers may prefer to **restart the war** than live with the result. A **power-sharing** system that gives every major group a slice of national power tends to be safer. → *Illustrates:* a lesson you simply cannot see by studying the US alone — the payoff of comparison.
- **Civil war & diamonds** (Collier & Hoeffler; **Sierra Leone**). A large **quantitative** study of hundreds of civil wars found that **ethnic division is not the main cause** people assume. War is far more likely where a group can seize a **valuable, lootable resource** — like the diamonds fuelling Sierra Leone's 1990s war. Where there's no such prize, ethnic division rarely turns violent. → *Illustrates:* the quantitative method + a genuinely counter-intuitive finding.
- **Ukraine 2014 — "is it a civil war?"** When fighting erupted in 2014 (with a Russian military presence backing one side), scholars couldn't cleanly classify it: *how much* violence, for *how long*, before it "counts" as a civil war? → *Illustrates:* the hard first step of any scientific study — **defining and measuring your variables** precisely.
- **Almond & Verba, *The Civic Culture* (1963).** They surveyed citizens across five countries and argued that stable democracies (US, UK) share a "**civic culture**" — people participate *and* defer enough to let leaders govern — whereas **Mexico** had a "**subject**" **culture** (citizens saw themselves as subjects, not participants), fitting its authoritarian rule until 2000. → *Illustrates:* the classic **modernist** political-culture claim — and the standard critique that culture may be an *effect* of institutions, not their cause.
- **US Catholics shifting Democrat → Republican.** Mid-20th-c. working-class Catholics voted **Democrat** on economic interest. As they grew affluent, they came to prioritise **moral/cultural** issues (e.g. abortion) and drifted **Republican**. → *Illustrates:* **postmaterialism** (Inglehart) — political culture *changing over time* and reshaping party alignments.
- **"Family values" (Reagan vs Clinton).** No US politician dares oppose "family values," yet the phrase has **no fixed meaning**: Reagan's Republicans used it to claim the traditional middle-class family; Clinton's Democrats **reinterpreted** it to mean single mothers and two-income families needing afterschool programmes. → *Illustrates:* the **postmodernist** point — political symbols are contested and redefined through **discourse** (a play for the 3rd dimension of power).
- **Unions: France / US / UK.** Same institution, three preference-sets: **French** unions tied themselves to the **Communist Party** and pursued broad ideological goals; **US** unions stayed "bread-and-butter" (wages & conditions), shunning socialist parties; **British** unions built their own **Labour Party**. →

Illustrates: the puzzle for **rational choice** — it takes preferences as given, so it can't explain *why* they differ so sharply across countries (this is the worked example above).

- **US two-term tradition** (Washington → FDR). Washington voluntarily stepped down after two terms; **no president broke the norm for 150+ years** until FDR won a third term in **1940** — after which it was written into the Constitution (22nd Amendment). → *Illustrates:* an **informal institution** that shaped behaviour purely because leaders and citizens believed it *should*.
- **Chile's democratic transition (1990s).** One of the most successful exits from military rule — explained three different ways: **rational-choice institutionalists** (elites cut a strategic constitutional bargain that served their interests), **political-culture** theorists (Chilean values favoured democracy), **historical institutionalists** (Chile could revive its earlier stable democratic institutions, a legacy neighbours lacked). → *Illustrates:* how the **same event** gets three competing explanations — and the analyst's job is to weigh them.
- **Sweden vs US welfare state.** Sweden runs a large, expensive welfare state; the US spends far less. Why do two rich democracies diverge? **Interests:** strong labour won in Sweden, business overpowered labour in the US. **Beliefs:** Sweden's dominant Socialists spread social-democratic ideology; US "make it on your own" culture rejects socialism. **Institutions:** Sweden's unified labour body (LO) became central to policymaking; US unions stayed decentralised and weak. → *Illustrates:* the lead "**Where and why?**" puzzle, with one answer from each theory family.
- **US corporate power / oligarchy** (Winters). Is the US genuinely democratic if a **corporate elite** holds outsized power? Winters argues extreme wealth ("material power") lets **oligarchs** hire lawyers and lobbyists to shield their income from redistribution. → *Illustrates:* a "**Who rules?**" case pitting **elite theory** against **pluralism**.

The 11 recurring countries (used across the whole book): Britain, Germany, Japan, USA (wealthy democracies) · China, Russia (post-communist) · India (largest democracy) · Iran (theocracy) · Brazil, Mexico, Nigeria (post-authoritarian).

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Politics	Process by which communities make collective decisions (procedural; group, whole community, ≠ polity/policy)
Polity / Policy	The rules & institutions / the outcomes (vs *politics* = the process)
Distributional game	Politics as allocating resources — "who gets what" (Lasswell; Easton)
Scarcity / Preference heterogeneity	The two assumptions behind the distributional view of politics
Comparative politics	Subfield comparing power/decision-making across countries
Three faces of power	(1) decision-making, Dahl; (2) agenda-setting, Bachrach & Baratz; (3) ideological, Lukes
Empirical / Normative theory	Explains what *does* / what *ought to* occur
Single-case study	Deep study of one case (uses process tracing)
Comparative method	Careful case selection: most-similar vs most-different systems
Rational choice theory	Actors rationally pursue self-defined preferences
Political culture	Widely held attitudes/values/symbols about politics
Civic culture	Culture supporting stable democracy (Almond & Verba)
Political ideology	Conscious systematic belief-set about how politics *ought* to be
Institutionalism	Institutions ("rules of the game") explain behavior
Pluralist theory	Power dispersed among competing groups
Elite theory	A small elite controls virtually all power
Patriarchy	Rule by men

Exam pointers

- Be able to **apply the 3 dimensions of power** to an example, and say which theory family "sees" which dimension.
- Know the **Interests / Beliefs / Structures** trichotomy for Q1 and **Pluralist vs Elite** for Q2 — with one named theorist per box (the names are in the two tables above: e.g. Interests → *Achen & Bartels / Petersen*; Beliefs → *Almond & Verba, Inglehart, Foucault*; Structures → *Marx, Weingast*; Pluralist → *Dahl*; Elite → *Mills, Winters, Alexander*).
- Distinguish **most-similar vs most-different** systems designs with an example.
- Always flag **empirical vs normative** when a question mixes them.

Ansell — *Why Politics Fails*, Ch. 1

Book: Ben Ansell (2023), *Why Politics Fails: The Five Traps of the Modern World – and How to Escape Them*, Penguin.

> *Note:* the provided PDF is titled "**Introduction: Simple Problems, Impossible Politics**" — this is the framing chapter the syllabus lists as "chapter 1." It sets up the whole book.

Chapter résumé

Ansell argues that our biggest challenges (climate change is the opening example) are often "**simple problems with impossible politics**": we understand the solution but can't get people to act. The reason is **political economy** — individuals are **self-interested**, and self-interest predictably collides with the collective good, producing **collective-action problems**. He introduces the **five goals** we broadly agree on — **Democracy, Equality, Solidarity, Security, Prosperity** — each of which is also a **trap**. Politics is fundamentally about making **collective promises** to each other; but promises can't be externally enforced, so they only work when made **self-enforcing** through **institutions** and **norms**. The book's project: learn to spot the five traps and escape them.

> ★ **The heart of the chapter:** one chain explains why politics fails — **self-interest → collective-action problem → tragedy of the commons → the need for self-enforcing political promises (institutions & norms)**. If you learn one thing here, learn to run that chain.

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **Political economy** — model individuals as self-interested utility-maximizers, then scale up to society.
- **Self-interest → preferences → constraints → trade-offs** — the micro engine.
- **Collective-action problem** — self-interested individuals undermine a shared goal.
- **Tragedy of the commons** & **externalities** (negative/positive) — the recurring failure shapes.
- **Politics as promises** — collective, unenforceable, needing **self-enforcing** design.
- **Institutions** (formal rules) & **norms** (informal expectations) — what makes promises stick.
- **The Five Traps:** Democracy · Equality · Solidarity · Security · Prosperity.

Section-by-section main points

Opening — Simple Problems, Impossible Politics

- Climate change: science is a century old and well understood; the road from emissions → warming is *simple*. The hard part is getting anyone to act — a **global problem with domestic politics**. No world government to enforce, so everyone free-rides.
- International attempts show politics *can* work (Paris 2015) or fail (Kyoto, Copenhagen) — success came from flexibility, vague wording, deferral.

- Climate tests all **five** goals: democracy (global consensus?), equality (should richer pay more?), solidarity (do rich nations owe poor?), security (climate refugees, enforcement?), prosperity (short-term gain vs long-term survival).

Common ground

- **Politics** = how we make collective decisions / make promises to each other in an uncertain world. Essential for solving shared dilemmas.
- **Double-edged sword:** we need politics but hate it; we look for alternatives (markets, technology, strong leaders) but these are "**false gods**" — they still run into human disagreement.
- Disagreement is **inevitable** (elections have losers; spending is unequal; who guards the guards?). Push politics down in one place, it pops up elsewhere ("paste in the toothpaste tube").
- Despite polarization, most people **agree on five things** — which are also five **traps**.

The five goals (each a trap)

- **Democracy** — right/ability of the mass public to choose and replace leaders. ~½ the world lives in democracies; broadly popular (86% in World Values Survey favor it) but under pressure (the "third wave" stalled; populism, referendums, attacks on media/expertise).
- **Equality** — everyone treated the same; but debate over *outcomes* vs *opportunities* and redistribution. Wide consensus that income gaps are too large (2019: only 7% disagreed), yet inequality has *risen* in rich countries since the 1980s → populist backlash ("inequality paradox").
- **Solidarity** — support for fellow citizens in hard times (illness, bad luck). Underpins popular "third-rail" policies (US Social Security, UK NHS). COVID-19 showed global health interdependence.
- **Security** — the most basic desire: to be safe. 70% prefer security over freedom (highest where war is recent). Concerns: violence *within* states, police violence ("who guards us from our protectors?"), return of interstate war (Ukraine).
- **Prosperity** — enough money to live/grow; but endless growth warms the planet → trade-off between prosperity and environmental survival.

Political economy (the method)

- The school of thought taking seriously how individual and society interact: start with a **model of each of us** (what we want + how we plan to get it), then pan out to society and watch **best-laid plans undermined by… us**.
- **Basic model:** everyone is **self-interested** — has ordered **preferences** and tries to **maximize utility** (pick the highest-value option). Not an ethical claim — a *predictive analytical tool*.
- **Methodological individualism:** start from individuals, not classes/cultures/groups.
- **Constraints & trade-offs:** you can't have everything (physical, institutional, social limits) → every choice sacrifices an alternative (coffee vs tea; lower taxes vs social liberalism at the ballot box).
- Even **voting** is a puzzle: your single vote is unlikely to be decisive, so turnout must be partly explained by a sense of **duty**. Politicians too are self-interested (must win elections → campaign arms race).

- Studying self-interest is **liberating**, not cynical: even apparently selfless behavior often has a self-interested logic (e.g. the rich opposing public-education spending that "devalues" their kids' advantage).

Collective-action problems

- When self-interested individuals interact, they can inadvertently wreck a shared goal.
- **Example — the Cod Wars** (Britain vs Iceland, 1950s–70s): overfishing a shared resource.
- **Tragedy of the commons:** without ownership, everyone fishes freely → stocks collapse; my self-interest hurts yours.
- **Externalities:** a market action's effect on a third party — mostly **negative** (pollution, congestion), sometimes **positive** (a neighbor's rose garden). Political life is "full of externalities."
- Root cause: we are **interdependent** — my choice affects your options — and we can't commit others (or ourselves) to "do the right thing." *The making of a tragedy.*

Politics as a promise

- We're *smart*: we anticipate what others will do — which is exactly why collective-action problems arise (can't blame "stupidity").
- Politics = making **collective promises** (politicians→voters, allies→adversaries). A **promise** ≠ a **contract**: it **can't be legally enforced by a third party** — there's *no higher power than politics itself*.
- So political promises are **fragile and temporary**; they succeed only when **self-enforcing** — designed so that reneging is hard.
- Two tools to grant promises permanence:
  - **Institutions** — formal rules/organizations that lock in expectations (e.g. the **US Senate filibuster**: powerful, flawed, over-represents small states, hard to remove safely — shows institutions structure behavior even when dysfunctional).
  - **Norms** — informal expectations about how we should behave; invisible but powerful, vaguer and harder to enforce than rules; not every leader can invoke them.
- Because institutions & norms vary, **politics plays out differently around the world** (e.g. Nordic high-trust, inclusive systems are hard to transplant).

The traps (close)

- Each of the five goals faces a **trap triggered by self-interest** that blocks the collective goal. Traps aren't destiny — but they're **insidious, pervasive, even enticing**.
- Two options: spot the traps "in the wild" and step around them, or — if already caught — learn to **escape**. *Only by understanding why politics fails can we make it succeed.*

The chain, run once (worked). This is the single argument the whole chapter builds — here it is end-to-end on the Cod Wars:

1. **Self-interest.** Every fisherman, British and Icelandic, tries to maximise his *own* catch (the political-economy starting model).

2. → **Collective-action problem.** They're **interdependent** — fishing the *same* sea — so each one acting on self-interest undermines the shared goal (a sustainable stock). Individually rational, collectively ruinous.
3. → **Tragedy of the commons** / **externality.** The sea is **unowned and hard to monitor**, so no one can be excluded → everyone overfishes → the stock collapses (**tragedy of the commons**). Put the other way: my extra catch imposes a cost on you — a **negative externality**.
4. → **Need for political promises.** We'd all be better off with a binding catch limit, but there's **no world government** to enforce one — so the *states* must make **political promises** to each other on behalf of their fishermen.
5. → **Institutions & norms.** A promise can't be enforced by any third party, so it only holds if it's **self-enforcing** — locked in by **institutions** (formal rules: recognised fishing limits/zones) and **norms** (informal expectations). When Iceland kept *extending* its limits, the promise broke and new ones were needed — "*politics never ends.*"

Reusable template (works on any trap): name the **self-interest** → show the **interdependence** that makes it a **collective-action problem** → identify the **commons/externality** failure → state the **promise** that would fix it → name the **institution/norm** that could make the promise stick.

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Political economy	Study of how self-interested individuals and society interact
Self-interest	Model assumption: people pursue their own ordered preferences
Utility maximization	Choosing the option that yields the highest personal value
Constraint / trade-off	Limits force sacrifice of one option for another
Collective-action problem	Self-interested individuals undermine a shared goal
Tragedy of the commons	Unowned shared resource gets over-exploited
Externality	Effect of a transaction on a third party (negative/positive)
Politics-as-promise	Collective promises that no third party can enforce
Self-enforcing	Arrangement where reneging is made costly/hard
Institution	Formal rule/organization locking in expectations (e.g. filibuster)
Norm	Informal expectation about proper behavior
The Five Traps	Democracy, Equality, Solidarity, Security, Prosperity

Exam pointers

- Memorize the **five goals/traps** (Democracy, Equality, Solidarity, Security, Prosperity) — the spine of the whole book.

- Be able to **run the chain**: self-interest → collective-action problem → tragedy of the commons/externalities → need for political promises → institutions & norms *(worked end-to-end above)*.
- Use the **Cod Wars** / **tragedy of the commons** as your go-to worked example.
- Key distinction: a **promise** (unenforceable, needs to be self-enforcing) vs a **contract** (third-party enforced).

Bridge to OD

Both readings converge on **institutions** and on modelling actors via **interests/self-interest** (OD's "Interests" family = Ansell's political-economy engine). Ansell's "politics = collective decisions" is almost verbatim OD's definition of **politics**. Good to cite them together on *why institutions matter*.

★ Fun facts & memorable details

> The sticky examples, surprising stats and quotable lines from this module — the stuff worth dropping into an essay or exam answer.

Memorable examples (great to cite)

- **The Cod Wars** (Britain vs Iceland, 1950s–70s): two NATO allies clashing over cod — boats rammed, one accidental death by electrocution, and Icelandic coastguards fitting **wire-cutters** to slash British trawler nets. A perfect little tragedy-of-the-commons story. *(Ansell)*
- **Civil war & diamonds:** statistical research (Collier & Hoeffler) found civil wars are driven more by control of **lootable resources** — diamonds, e.g. Sierra Leone — than by ethnic division. *(OD)*
- **The "new Jim Crow"** (Michelle Alexander): mass incarceration reframed as a modern system of racial control. *(OD)*
- **George Washington's two-term tradition:** an *informal* institution that held for 150+ years until FDR broke it in 1940 — then it was locked into the Constitution. *(OD)*
- "**Family values**" as a contested symbol — Reagan's Republicans and Clinton's Democrats each reinterpreted it (the postmodernist point about discourse). *(OD)*

Surprising stats

- **86%** worldwide (World Values Survey) say democracy is a good way to run a country — and in **China, Ethiopia, Iran & Tajikistan over 90%** agree with pro-democracy statements, *more* than in the US. *(Ansell)*
- **~70%** say they'd prefer **security over freedom** — highest where war is recent. *(Ansell)*
- **~95%** across wealthy countries think government should provide healthcare — even **85% in the US**. *(Ansell)*
- **2016** was, by some counts, the **most violent year since WWII**. *(Ansell)*

Quotable lines

- Marx: the modern state is "*the executive committee of the whole bourgeoisie.*" *(OD)*

- Keynes: "*In the long run we are all dead.*" — on why forecasting fails. *(Ansell)*
- Ansell on the inescapability of politics: push it down in one place and it pops up in another, "*like the proverbial paste in the toothpaste tube.*"
- The **NHS** as Britain's "*national religion.*" *(Ansell)*

Trivia

- OD's example of why natural science can be "purer": South Korea's **Woo Suk Hwang faked stem-cell results** — but biologists don't get *normatively* attached to findings the way political scientists do.
- The CO_2-warming theory dates to **1861**, revived in a **1956 New York Times** piece imagining "tigers roaming… and squawking Arctic parrots." *(Ansell)*
